Atlanta Botanical Garden - Expansion

American Smoketree

Cotinus obovatus

Family: Not stated Also known as: —

GARDENS Beltline: 3 **TOTAL 3**



Summer / form
Library candidate



Fall color
Library candidate

Not available

Flower
Not available



Leaf close-up
Library candidate

QUICK FACTS & PLANTING

Type: Tree
Evergreen/Deciduous: Deciduous
Mature size: 20–30 ft. Confirmed by Missouri Botanical Garden, Oregon State, Morton Arboretum, Gardenia, UF/IFAS. × 15–30 ft. Confirmed range.
Hardiness / Zone 8a: Suitable for Zone 8a. Hardy Zones 4–8. Native to southern U.S. including parts of the Southeast. Performs in Atlanta. Drought tolerant once established. Best in full sun for fall color and form. Restart pass (2026-10-13): NC State confirms native to rocky limestone soils in the South, full sun preferred, wide soil tolerance including clay, excellent fall color, smoke-like flower clusters. [https://plants.ces.ncsu.edu/plants/cotinus-obovatus/]
Sun: Full sun. Tolerates light shade.
Water: Medium to low once established. Drought tolerant. Prefers well-drained.
Soil: Well-drained. Adaptable (including poor, rocky, alkaline). Prefers somewhat infertile. Avoid wet soils.
Growth rate: Not stated
Not stated
Planting:
Siting: Plant in full sun in well-drained soil. Tolerates poor and rocky soils. Water regularly until established, then drought tolerant. Avoid overwatering. Minimal pruning. Suitable as specimen or small tree.
Soil prep: Well-drained. Adaptable (including poor, rocky, alkaline). Prefers somewhat infertile. Avoid wet soils.
Depth/spacing: Not stated
Season: Not stated
Establishment: Not stated

ORIGIN, CHARACTERISTICS & HEALTH

Origin / native: Native to rocky limestone glades, bluffs, and bald knobs in the southern U.S.
Form / habit: Deciduous. Small tree or large shrub. Rounded to oval. Slow to medium growth.
Foliage: Yellow, orange, red, purple (excellent).
Flowers / fruit: Not stated
Bark / stem: Gray-brown, flaky, developing ridges.
Not stated
Health:
Health notes: Relatively trouble-free. Possible verticillium wilt in some conditions. Minimal insect and disease problems noted by multiple sources. **Open:** Specific Zone 8a incidence is thin.
Not stated
Additional:
- “Smoke” from billowy pink-purple hairs on spent flower stalks in summer. - Insignificant yellowish-green flowers. - Obovate bluish-green leaves. - Excellent multi-color fall foliage. - Dioecious (male trees often showier smoke).